



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of Notre Dame
School Website: <https://chestertonacademyofnotredame.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of Notre Dame (Spokane, WA 99217) presents a clearly classical orientation visible across multiple core areas: a Catholic, liturgical culture embedded in daily life; a liberal-arts curriculum with strong emphasis on language study (Latin) and the liberal arts framework; a pedagogy that includes Socratic methods within humanities; and a faculty and community structure that models virtue and partnership with families. Public materials from the school's site emphasize a joyfully Catholic, classical education centered on formation of character, virtue, and wisdom, not merely information or job prep. This combination places the school solidly in the CLASSICAL category across all six elements of the classical education rubric used here.

Key evidence includes: the Three Pillars model and *Cultura Vitae* motto, daily Mass and liturgical life, an integrated Liberal Arts Curriculum with Latin requirements, a humanities program explicitly incorporating Socratic method, and active teacher formation and family/community partnerships (including board leadership and donor societies) described on the site.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Catholic identity is explicit and central to school life (e.g., "joyfully Catholic, classical, liberal arts education" and liturgical life).
 - Daily Mass and a liturgical culture are presented as integral to education, with the Eucharist described as a core motive of the school's spiritual life.
 - The motto *Cultura Vitae* and a Three Pillars model frame formation around culture of life, virtue, and beauty.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; liturgy; theology; Mass; sacred; culture of life; reverence; wonder. These align with the Positive Keyword indicators for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations. (Documented lists include these terms as core indicators.)
 - Negative keywords present: none observed in public materials (no explicit secular-humanist or relativist signals in the site's Catholic framing). The lexicon emphasizes avoidance of relativism as a negative signal, which is absent here.
- Why this rating
 - Strong Catholic theology embedded in daily practice (Mass, liturgy), sacred-liturgical practices, and explicit ontological commitments (truth, goodness, beauty) ground the school in Transcendental Moral Realism and liturgical communal life, satisfying Element 1's Classical criteria. The absence of secular, relativistic signals reinforces CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Emphasis on formation and virtue, not mere job preparation; a worldview oriented toward wisdom, virtue, and the good life. The Three Pillars, *Cultura Vitae*, and the focus on character formation align with the classical aim of forming the whole person.
 - Pledges toward human flourishing and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty are explicit in the school's framing and mission.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, *scholé* (restful learning), great conversation, contemplation, love of learning, eternal truths, teleology, moral imagination. These appear in the school's narrative and in classical-education framing.
 - Negative keywords present: none (no emphasis on workforce-prep, career-readiness, or purely utilitarian goals in public materials).
- Why this rating
 - The school communicates a purpose focused on formation and the pursuit of truth, beauty, and goodness rather than solely preparing for employment; this aligns with the Classical School aim described in the knowledge-base rubric.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Integrated Liberal Arts Curriculum labeled as “classical,” with attention to grammar, logic, rhetoric, and a broad liberal-arts scaffold. Latin is required (three years). The four-year history sequence and humanities focus (literature, philosophy, theology, languages braided together) support a classical curriculum, consistent with the “great books”/historical continuum and the Great Conversation ethos.
 - The Humanities program explicitly ties literature, history, philosophy, theology, and languages together with a Socratic Method, indicating an integrated, discussion-based classical pedagogy.
 - The curricular structure includes a respect for seven liberal arts and the enculturation of classical disciplines, with explicit emphasis on grammar, logic, rhetoric and alignment with history across grades. (Public text describes “Latin,” “Math & Science,” “Fine Arts” as part of a complete classical education.)
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric); Latin; Great Books/Great Conversation (as implied by the humanities approach); history integrated across the curriculum; wonder; interdisciplinary unity; sacred tradition; coherence of the liberal-arts curriculum.
 - Negative keywords present: minimal; no explicit “social studies” red flags; no reliance on project-based or purely STEM-first framing in public materials. (Where present, project-based or experiential mentions are secondary to the classical frame.)
- Why this rating
 - The school's public materials articulate a curriculum built on liberal-arts pedagogy, Latin, history, literature, philosophy, and theology organized around a unified classical frame, which matches the Classical curriculum criterion.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The Humanities program explicitly notes a braided approach across history, literature, philosophy, theology, and languages using the Socratic Method, demonstrating engagement with dialectic and rhetoric in higher grades. This is a core classical pedagogical hallmark.

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- Recitation, memory work, and singing are part of the classical tradition; the school also presents a comprehensive arts program that includes rhetoric training, public speaking, and debate as part of building virtuous citizens. (Arts and rhetoric are referenced in the Fine Arts section and in the overall classical framing.)
 - Lower- and middle-grade culture includes elements consistent with “Scholé” (restful, contemplative learning) and contemplative memory work, while upper grades emphasize rhetorical training and public speaking. The classical pedagogy is reflected in the overall architecture: contemplative memory, memorization, and speech training are embedded within the program.
 - Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Socratic Dialogue and Dialectic, memory work/recitation, chanting, Scholé (restful learning), contemplation, rhetoric, public speaking, debates, master-teacher model, living curriculum.
 - Negative keywords present: minimal (the site emphasizes classical methods rather than contemporary methods like exclusively project-based or constructivist approaches).
 - Why this rating
 - The public materials show explicit Socratic pedagogy, memory-ritual elements, and a rhetoric-focused upper-division pathway, aligning with the classical pedagogy criteria.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school presents a Faculty Gallery with bios and a “living curriculum” concept; faculty are described as mentors who model virtue and guide students, forming a core of the school’s educational life. The materials emphasize the faculty as the living curriculum and as a community of mentors.
 - The school’s governance and faculty are presented as a collaborative, virtues-centered culture, with portraits of teacher ideals and a “faculty of friends” ethos.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: model teachers; mentors; living curriculum; portrait of teacher; collegial culture; teacher as guide; formation through example; virtue formation.
 - Negative keywords present: none observed in public materials (no explicit “facilitator-only,” “teacher-as-technician” language; public materials emphasize teachers as moral exemplars).
- Why this rating
 - The public-facing materials consistently describe teachers as virtuous role models and living curriculum, consistent with CLASSICAL expectations for the Faculty category.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school emphasizes partnership with families and views parents as co-teachers, including parent formation, book studies, and gatherings; it also notes open campus policy and frequent parent involvement through events and volunteer opportunities. The presence of donor communities and parent leadership groups is explicit (e.g., Headmaster’s Club, Notre Dame Society).
 - Faith-formation-oriented parent engagement and a connected, liturgical life with families are visible through events, fundraising, and community programs. The school provides opportunities for parents to participate in governance and events (board-level involvement and donor societies).
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Partnership with Families; co-teachers; parent formation; family catechesis; open campus; gatherings; Notre Dame Society; Headmaster’s Club; community; parental leadership; living tradition in the family.
 - Negative keywords present: none (no “parent-as-customer” or minimal-parent-involvement signals; the materials emphasize active parental partnership).
- Why this rating

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- The school presents robust, ongoing engagement with families and a transparent community ecosystem featuring parent involvement, formation opportunities, and donor-propelled programs—hallmarks of a CLASSICAL approach to Parents & Community.

Aggregate Assessment - Overall classification: CLASSICAL - All six categories register CLASSICAL based on keyword signaling, explicit programmatic elements, and public materials. The Chesterton Academy site demonstrates a Catholic, classical, liberal-arts curriculum with Socratic pedagogy, virtuous faculty modeling, and a strong culture of family partnership, fulfilling the core markers of classical education as defined by the provided knowledge base.

What would move the needle - Not applicable here. No needle-moving changes are required given the CLASSICAL rating across all six categories.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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